into sub-orbit. The year was 1961 and US President John F. Kennedy was faced with a dilemma.

He realised the importance of the Space Race given the Cold War they were engaged in, and the constant beating at the hands of the Soviets was leaving the American public disillusioned and alarmed. Kennedy needed a big win and so he called upon his Vice President, Lyndon Johnson, to sit down with the NASA officials and figure out a project which they could accomplish before the Soviet Union.

After several meetings, Johnson and NASA administrator James Webb noted that a mission to land a man on the moon was far enough into the future that they could achieve it first.

On May 25, 1961, just three short weeks after Alan Shepard's legendary flight, President Kennedy went to Congress for an address on "Urgent National Needs."

Kennedy told Congress and the nation that "space is open to us now", and said that space exploration may hold the key to our future here on Earth. Backing the pre-existing Apollo programme and making it into NASA's prime concern, he laid forth an audacious challenge:

"I believe that this nation should commit itself to achieving the goal, before this decade is out, of landing a man on the moon and returning him safely to Earth."

Project Gemini

While Apollo was going to be the project that finally took man to the moon, it was still a long way away from what NASA had achieved with Project Mercury at the time. There needed to be a bridge between Mercury and Apollo for the scientists to learn more about space travel, vehicular technology and its effects on astronauts. Out of this need, 'Project Gemini' was born on January 3, 1962.

The Gemini Programme had four objectives: 1) To subject astronauts to long duration flights – a requirement for projected later trips to the moon or deeper space; 2) to develop effective methods of rendezvous and docking with other orbiting vehicles, and to manoeuvre the docked vehicles in space; 3) to perfect methods of re-entry and landing the spacecraft at a pre-selected land-landing point; 4) to gain additional information concerning the effects of weightlessness on crew members and to record the physiological reactions of crew members during long duration flights.

The name 'Gemini' was derived from the spacecraft's new requirement